

Strong winds bring new anxiety

After making progress against blazes, firefighters face another round of Santa Anas



A FIREFIGHTER puts out hot spots Saturday at a home destroyed by the Eaton fire. The blaze, which has burned more than 14,100 acres, was 33% contained Monday.

ANSWERS MAY LIE ALONG BELOVED TRAIL

BY RICHARD WINTON, NOAH GOLDBERG AND HANNAH FRY

Hikers and outdoor enthusiasts have long been drawn to Skull Rock north of Sunset Boulevard in Pacific Palisades.

A relatively short hike on the Temescal Ridge trail reveals the skeletal-shaped Skull Rock and dramatic Pacific Ocean views.

Now, this area is the subject of an investigation as a potential starting point for the Palisades fire, which burned thousands of structures last week.

It's unclear where the fire started, and its cause is under investigation.

The general area was the site of a small blaze on New Year's Eve that burned for a few hours before fire officials said they snuffed it out with help from a water-dropping helicopter.

Sources with knowledge of the investigation told The Times that officials are aware of the earlier fire and its general proximity to the Palisades fire. They are looking into whether that could be the cause. Because the area is frequented by the public, the sources said it's possible a new fire was somehow sparked there on Jan. 7.

The earlier fire appears to have been sparked by fireworks, officials said.

As for the Palisades fire, the sources — who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly — said [See **Trail**, A6]



LAPD officers keep the public away from the Skull Rock area of the Temescal Ridge trail, which is being investigated as the potential origin of the Palisades fire.

Was poor brush clearance a factor?

BY ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

The allegations flew as fast as the flames. The Palisades fire raging through the coastal mountains of Los Angeles, rich and powerful critics said, wouldn't have been quite so devastating had authorities done a bet-

ter job of clearing hillside brush.

"We knew the winds were coming. We knew that there was brush that needed to be cleared 20 years ago," Rick Caruso, the developer and former Los Angeles mayoral candidate, told The Times. "This fire could have been mitigated — maybe not pre-

vented."

Elon Musk wrote on X that the "biggest factor, in my opinion, is that crazy environmental regulations prevent building firebreaks and clearing brush near houses." And actor-producer Sara Foster chimed in with an X post saying "our vegetation was overgrown,

brush not cleared."

Did these and other second-guessers have a point? Scientists, wildfire specialists and firefighting officials had differing viewpoints. But several of these experts — including strong proponents of brush clearance — said that the winds fanning [See **Palisades**, A5]

Eaton fire throws actor into painful role: victim

BY JEFFREY FLEISHMAN

She lost everything, but wanted her dignity.

"You know," she said, "I walked on red carpets at movie openings around the world. But..."

She paused and glanced away.

"I have no underwear," she whispered. "I'm sorry to say such a thing. It is what has happened to me."

Gloria Sandoval woke up Sunday morning on a Red Cross cot in the evacuation shelter at the Pasadena Convention Center. The house she was renting in Al-



GLORIA Sandoval, an actor who lost the Altadena home she was renting, shows a photo of the damage.

tadena was incinerated days earlier, and Sandoval, 67, dressed in slippers, a sweat-shirt and baggy pants, walked among those like her, people devastated by a storm of wind and flame that hurtled through canyons and raced across highlands. "My mind is lost," she said. "I'm confused. Sometimes, I cannot speak. I wonder to myself, 'What are you doing here?' I want to go back to my house. My jewelry, my clothes, my pictures, so many pictures. All gone. I have only my pajamas and my little cat, Chispita."

Sandoval, an actor for [See **Sandoval**, A7]

the San Fernando Valley and part of Los Angeles and the San Gabriel Valley, bringing wind gusts ranging from 45 mph to 70 mph.

Officials have been able to make progress over the last few days thanks to an easing of winds, which allowed for an aerial campaign that stopped the Palisades fire from hitting Brentwood and Encino. Authorities hope to be able to keep aircraft up Tuesday, but it's unclear how much the conditions will allow.

"We are not in the clear as of yet, and we must not let our guard down," Los Angeles [See **Wildfires**, A5]

For Bass, response to crisis is litmus test

BY JULIA WICK

Apocalyptic fires had been ravaging Los Angeles for more than 24 hours when Mayor Karen Bass stepped off a plane and into a now-viral encounter that may come to define her mayoralty.

As an Irish reporter who happened to be on her flight hurled questions at her, the mayor of the nation's second-largest metropolis stood silent and seemingly paralyzed.

"Do you owe citizens an apology for being absent while their homes were burning?" No answer.

"Do you regret cutting the fire department budget by millions of dollars, Madame Mayor?" No answer.

Have you nothing to say today?"

Bass stared forward, [See **Bass**, A7]

MORE FIRE COVERAGE INSIDE

What sparked blazes?

Officials say it could take months or longer to determine the causes of the Palisades and Eaton fires. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Work versus safety

Employees, bosses wrestle with whether to keep workplaces open. Some firms are more flexible than others. **BUSINESS, A8**

A quick relocation

It was no small feat moving the Rams-Vikings playoff game to Arizona because of the fires, Sam Farmer writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Famed homes lost

A look at the landmark residences, such as the Bridges House, that have been destroyed. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly sunny; breezy. L.A. Basin: 69/46. **B6**

